

Max McDonough

SOCS 202 — Ecological Perspectives

Reflection: “Why We Need New Stories on Climate” — Rebecca Solnit

Solnit’s essay is basically arguing that the climate crisis isn’t just about carbon or policy failures — it’s a failure of imagination. The stories we’ve been handed about what progress means and how the world works have boxed us into thinking nothing can really change. She goes after the helplessness narrative pretty directly — the idea that the problem is too big, that individual action doesn’t matter, that corporations will never change. Her point is that those stories aren’t neutral observations. They’re doing work. They keep people passive, and passivity is what the current system runs on. She’s not saying we should just be optimistic — she’s saying that treating the future as already decided is its own kind of giving up.

What actually stuck with me reading this was thinking about it through design. I’m in interaction design, and so much of what we build tells a story whether we mean it to or not. An infinite scroll is a story about attention — that yours belongs to the platform. One-click purchasing is a story about friction — that thinking before buying is a problem to be solved. These aren’t just features, they’re narratives baked into the interface. Solnit is talking about journalism and activism mostly, but I think the argument applies just as much to the products we use every day. If the old stories live in our infrastructure — in the apps, the feeds, the checkout flows — then that’s also where new ones have to show up.

Three ideas from the reading I found compelling:

1. Despair as a form of denial. This one got me. She basically flips the common framing — usually we think of denial as refusing to accept the science, but Solnit argues that hopelessness does the same thing. If you decide nothing can change, you don't have to do anything. It's comfortable in its own way. That reframe is honestly kind of uncomfortable to sit with because I've definitely been in that headspace before.
2. Change doesn't happen gradually — it builds invisibly and then hits all at once. She brings up examples of movements that looked like they were failing for years and then suddenly won. I think in design we're trained to expect measurable, linear progress — sprints, metrics, iteration cycles. But systemic change doesn't work that way, and that tension between how design thinks about progress and how social change actually happens feels important.
3. Stories aren't metaphors for action — they are action. The narratives a culture tells about what's normal and what's possible literally shape what gets built, what gets funded, what gets ignored. This connects to what we've been talking about in class with shadow constitutions and how technology embeds values. The story a product tells about how life should work becomes the infrastructure people live inside.

Three questions for discussion:

1. Where is the line between designing for new narratives and just being manipulative? Like, if we're designing interfaces that try to shift people's behaviour toward sustainability, how is that different from the persuasive design techniques that got us into this mess? When does it become just a different kind of dark pattern?
2. Solnit talks mostly about stories in writing and media, but I'd argue the most powerful stories right now are being told through interaction design — through the structure of apps, platforms, recommendation algorithms. What would it look like to actually apply her framework to how we design digital products? What does a "new story" look like as a UX pattern?
3. She makes a distinction between hope and optimism that I think is really useful — hope as recognizing the future hasn't been written yet. But in a design studio driven by client briefs and business KPIs, everything assumes continuity with how things already are. Is there space for that kind of open-endedness in professional practice, or does it only really exist in speculative/critical design?